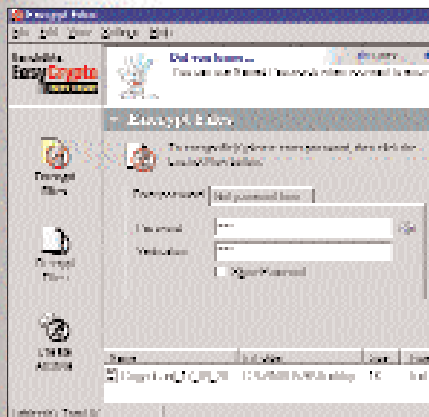




Protect your sensitive data with EasyCrypto

data (known as decryption), you need to provide a secret key or password. This ensures that no one besides you will have access to the data.

You can encrypt your data using free encryption software such as HandyBits EasyCrypto Deluxe.

EasyCrypto allows you to encrypt files and folders with password protection. To encrypt files, click on the 'Add Files' button in the 'Encrypt Files' dialog box. Now, browse to select the files you need to encrypt and click on 'Open'. Enter the password that will decrypt the files. To complete the encryption, click on the 'Encrypt Now' button. To decrypt the files, click on the 'Decrypt Files' icon. Add the files using

General Safeguards

- Disable 'File/Print Sharing'. This feature has a lot of vulnerabilities.
- If you need to share folders, share them as hidden folders. For this add a '\$' sign after the folder name. For example, if you need to share a folder named music, share it as music\$. Also make it a habit to assign passwords.
- Rename your Administrator account in Windows 2000/NT/XP. This will make it harder for people to get access to your machine.
- Use a combination of alphabets and numbers in your password so that it's hard to guess and crack. Take any word, for example 'Digit' and frame your password by mapping the letters above each letter of the keyword 'Digit' on the keyboard. This is a good method to frame a password and it's extremely difficult

Exorcise the Ghost

You might have often used the [Shift] + [Del] combination to delete a file and bypass the Recycle Bin. And you rest content assuming that you've seen the last of that file. Wish it were that simple! The reality however is not quite so at all.

With the right tools, someone with the know-how could easily get hold of that data under a minute. When you delete a file, Windows only removes the name of the file from the File Allocation Table. The data remains on your hard disk

till other data is written over it. This is where File Shredders help. File Shredders completely remove the data from your hard disk by thoroughly overwriting it several times.

Eraser is one such file shredder, which helps you delete information completely from the hard disk. By default, it overwrites the file 36 times. It also lets you schedule erasing of data on a periodic basis. Cleaning up unused space in drives is also possible with Eraser.

'Add Files'. Enter the password and click on the 'Decrypt Now' button. The files will be restored to their original state.

If you want to encrypt an entire folder, use the [F3] key to browse to the folder. Add the folder and encrypt it as you would encrypt a file. You can also encrypt or decrypt files and folders from Windows Explorer by right-clicking on the file or folder and selecting the 'Encrypt' or 'Decrypt' options.

You can even mail encrypted files as self-extracting archives. For this, select the 'Send To Mail Recipient' box in 'Create Archive'. Add the file and click on 'Build Now'. The file will be converted to a self-extracting archive file and added as an attachment to a new mail from your mail client. You can also select the encryption key length as 40, 64, or 128 bits by clicking on the 'Options' button.

A charm for the network

The measures that we've discussed so far were all about how you can protect your data physically, i.e. how you can protect your computer from being accessed by intruders around you. Now let's take a look at protecting your PC from prying eyes when you are connected to the Internet. If you thought that just running an anti-virus would protect you, then you are in for a rude shock.

It is very easy for someone to get access to your PC on the Internet, especially if you have an 'always on' connection such as Cable Internet or DSL. These connections usually provide you with a static IP, an Internet address for your PC which is constant whenever you are connected to the Internet. Dial-up connections usually have a dynamic IP, which changes every time you log on to the Internet. Static IPs allow hackers easier access to a PC.

A personal firewall will help you secure

yourself from unwanted visitors. Your PC's doors, or its ports, are completely invisible to outsiders when you have a firewall running. A personal firewall also helps you safeguard yourself from spyware and Trojans. Spyware are programs that send information about you to software developers without your knowledge. Many freeware



You can prevent certain applications from accessing the Internet

and shareware programs are spyware. Trojans are basically programs you unknowingly install on your PC, which give hackers control of your PC.

Circle of fire

One of the best personal firewalls available is Zone Alarm from Zone Labs. It is free and installing it is pretty straightforward.

Zone Alarm is quite easy to use once you get the basics right. The first time you access the Net via a particular program (Web browser, chat client, etc) after

System Security 2001 (System Tools CD), HandyBits Easy Crypto Deluxe (System Tools CD), Eraser (System Tools CD), Zone Alarm (Internet Solutions CD)

